

Teaching Image Composition with Ukiyo-e and Digital Painting Application

Miho Aoki

University of Alaska Fairbanks

United States of America

maoki3@alaska.edu

Abstract

This abstract presents an image composition analysis assignment in an asynchronous distance-delivered traditional fine-art course that incorporates the use of digital tools.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → Arts and humanities; Fine arts; Education; Distance learning.

ACM Reference Format:

Miho Aoki. 2024. Teaching Image Composition with Ukiyo-e and Digital Painting Application. In *SIGGRAPH Asia 2024 Educator's Forum (SA Educator's Forum '24)*, December 03–06, 2024, Tokyo, Japan. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 2 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3680533.3697069>

1 Introduction

This abstract introduces simple, easy-to-adopt, and easy-to-implement Engaging Educational Techniques and Assignment for introductory two-dimensional art foundation courses.

2 Image Composition Analysis with Japanese Ukiyo-e Assignment

Paying attention to the overall pictorial balance is crucial for creating compelling images. The placement of visual features can drastically change the mood and message the images communicate [Lauer and Pentak, 2015][fig. 1]. This assignment is in the third module of the course and is designed to have students analyze image compositions and discuss how they affect the overall images.

Students are asked to choose an Ukiyo-e print from the 53 Stations of Tokaido series by Utagawa Hiroshige and observe the visual elements, such as major features, shapes negative spaces, and physical lines. Observing less-visible elements, such as implied and psychic lines, is also an important objective of this assignment. They are directed to focus on how their eyes move on the image. Then, students are asked to visually show their findings by drawing lines and arrows directly on the image [fig. 2].

The aim of this assignment is to pay attention to the overall flow and structure of the image composition. One of the challenges of teaching image composition is to help students pay attention to the formal aspects of images instead of the subject matter. Students

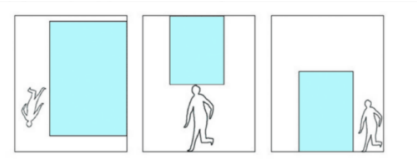


Figure 1: Lecture image showing how the placement of visual elements affects the impressions of images.

import a selected image into their application and draw lines to show their findings. Drawing lines directly allows students to actively pay attention to the image during the observation and communicate their findings visually.

In an earlier version of this assignment, students used images of their choice and submitted a written analysis. The images varied in style and subjects, and some were difficult to analyze, while others were too simple. Using Ukiyo-e prints can help students focus on the formal aspects of the images, making image composition analysis easier. Ukiyo-e images also show that engaging images don't always have to be highly detailed or physically correct. The 53 Stations of Tokaido images are available from public domain sources [Hiroshige, 1834] and the museum database, and students can learn about the images from the museum websites [Hiroshige, 1834].

In the assignment example, I demonstrate starting with outlining, moving on to finding less obvious features like applied and psychic lines and shapes of negative spaces, and then marking how the visual features guided the eyes on the image.

Finally, students are asked to describe how the image composition affects the overall impression of the image in brief writing, such as “it creates a strong movement” or “the stable and horizontal composition helps a sense of calmness in the image”.

Marked images and brief statements are collected for assessment and evaluated with the following criteria:

- **Identification of Key Elements:** Recognizing important lines, including implied and psychic lines, and prominent features, including negative shapes
- **Visual Dynamics and Balance:** Analyzing how visual elements guide the viewer's eye, contribute to the overall balance, and affect the sense of movement or stillness in the image.
- **Statement Relevance:** Relevance of the written statement to the overall image composition to the impression/mood of the image

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

SA Educator's Forum '24, December 03–06, 2024, Tokyo, Japan

© 2024 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1136-7/24/12

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3680533.3697069>



Figure 2: Original Image of “Yui” Utagawa Hiroshige. [Public domain], via The Metropolitan Museum of Art Open Access (left) and an example of the result (right).

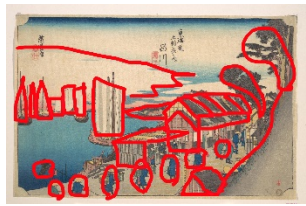


Figure 3: Example of Result not Achieving the Assignment Goal yet, Original image: Shinagawa, Utagawa Hiroshige. [Public domain], via The Metropolitan Museum of Art Open Access

Submissions outlining only prominent visible features [fig. 3] suggest that the students have not paid enough attention to less visible features like psychic lines and/or have not examined the overall balance, locations, sizes and angles of visual features carefully yet. Such submissions are returned for resubmission with comments recommending reviewing the lecture video and examples.

In the following module, students are asked to draw an original image, analyze it in a manner similar to the one they did in this assignment, and revise the drawing according to the mood and impression they are aiming for.

2.1 Limitations and Additional Ideas

The assignment is limited to a series of images with a distinctive, simple visual style. The visual style difference between these images and other media, such as photography, may present difficulty for some students in applying the concepts in other media. If time allows, analyzing images in other media with relatively simple style and distinctive image composition, such as photographs of Henri Cartier-Bresson, and moving on to more complex images can bridge the gap.

A group assignment using one image and having students share their observations and analysis can allow students to learn from each other. This can enhance understanding but also encourage diverse perspectives on visual interpretation.

References

- D. A. Lauer and S. Pentak. 2015. *Balance*. Design Basics. 9th ed. Cengage Learning, USA.86-104
- Utagawa Hiroshige. 1834. Satta Peak at Yui, from The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Retrieved October 6, 2024. <https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/36938>
- Utagawa Hiroshige. 1834. Shinagawa; Shoko Detachi, from The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Retrieved October 6, 2024. <https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/37035>